

## CORE FORMULA

Name the specific action -> name the positive effect -> keep it proportionate -> stop before it becomes flattery. -> "I appreciated how you grouped the actions; it saved everyone re-reading the thread." -> "Thanks for chasing the supplier twice; it's the reason we didn't slip the deadline." -> "The way you let the customer finish before answering is why they calmed down."

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one specific thing the person did and the effect it had, in a single plain sentence: "I appreciated X because it helped Y."

## BEST FOR

- Thanking colleagues for work that could easily go unseen
- Strengthening a relationship without resorting to flattery
- Reinforcing a helpful behaviour you'd like repeated
- Acknowledging good judgement or a quiet save
- Recognising support someone gave you
- Making appreciation land accurately rather than vaguely

## PHRASE BANK

### Quick · Everyday one-liners

- "That bit where you flagged the risk early was really helpful."
- "Thanks for catching that; it saved us a step."
- "The way you laid that out made it easy to follow."
- "Good call on the order of those points."
- "That was a clean summary; cheers."
- "Nicely handled, you kept it moving."
- "That one detail you added made the difference."

### Warm · Personal and relational

- "I noticed how patiently you talked them through it, and it mattered."
- "The way you checked in on me last week stuck with me."
- "You didn't have to stay back and help, and it made a real difference."
- "I appreciate how steady you were while everyone else was rattled."
- "That was generous; you gave them your full attention."
- "You made a hard conversation feel easy, so thank you."
- "The care you put into that really showed."

### Professional · Work, meetings and colleagues

- "I appreciated how you grouped the actions; it saved everyone re-reading the thread."
- "The way you clarified the plan at the end meant we all left knowing the next step."
- "You handled that client question well; naming the trade-off kept it honest."
- "Good structure on the deck, decisions first and detail second."
- "You spotted the gap in the timeline before it cost us; that was sharp."
- "Thanks for running that meeting to time; it respected everyone's day."
- "The way you documented that decision will save the next person a lot of guessing."

### Naming the effect · Point at what specifically helped

- "Here's the concrete thing that helped: you made the next step clear."
- "One specific bit, your timing on that email stopped it escalating."
- "The useful part was the example you gave; it made it land."
- "What worked was that you named the real problem, not the symptom."
- "To be exact: grouping the questions at the end saved us a second call."
- "The thing that mattered was you followed up without being asked."

### Digital / text · One clean line

- "Just want to name it: the way you framed that message was spot on."
- "That reply was clear and kind; good balance."
- "Thanks for the tidy handover notes; I picked it up in minutes."
- "Your one-line summary at the top saved me scrolling; appreciated."
- "Quick note, the checklist you added is going to help everyone."

### Guarded / high-status · Optional and low-pressure

- "I'll keep this brief because I know you'd rather not make a thing of it: that was well judged."
- "No need to respond, I just wanted you to know the fix you pushed held up."
- "Quietly, the way you defused that meeting took real skill."
- "I won't labour it, but calling that risk early was the right move."
- "If it's useful to hear, you read that room better than anyone."

### Repair · When it misses

- "I may have read that wrong; what actually helped from your side?"
- "Let me put that more simply."
- "That came out more polished than I meant; I just wanted to say thanks."
- "No need to make anything of it if it isn't useful."
- "I jumped ahead there; what I meant was the specific bit that helped."
- "Tell me the more accurate way to say it."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: You're amazing.

Better: I appreciated the way you clarified the plan at the end.

**Best: I appreciated the way you clarified the plan at the end; it meant everyone left knowing their next action without another meeting.**

2. Weak: Great job today.

Better: Thanks for chasing the supplier.

**Best: Thanks for chasing the supplier twice; it's the reason we didn't slip the deadline.**

3. Weak: You're so good with people.

Better: You handled that upset customer well.

**Best: The way you let that customer finish before answering is why they calmed down.**

## DECISION TREE

### If They're still speaking

Wait; don't interrupt to praise. Hold the appreciation until they finish.

### If You're not sure what actually helped

Use a checking version instead of asserting.

*"What was the part you were most trying to get right?"*

### If They seem to be resisting or bracing

Validate the concern before appreciating anything.

*"I know that was a slog, and the way you kept it moving mattered."*

**If They might read praise as the set-up for an ask**

Name it as standalone and make no request.

*"No ask attached; I just wanted to name it."*

**If The move landed and increased ease**

Continue naturally; don't over-egg it.

*"That's all, carry on."*

**If The move reduced ease or missed**

Repair or release it.

*"I may have read that wrong; what actually helped from your side?"*

## SCENARIOS

**Social conversation**

Keep it warm and brief; name one specific thing, then move on. — "That story you told earlier really landed; you read the room perfectly."

**Professional discussion**

Name the action and its effect clearly, tied to the work. — "Grouping the actions at the top of the notes saved everyone re-reading the thread."

**Digital message**

Write one clean sentence and avoid overexplaining. — "Your one-line summary at the top saved me scrolling; thank you."

**Conflict or objection**

Validate or summarise before you appreciate anything. — "I know that wasn't easy to raise, and you raised it cleanly."

**High-status or guarded person**

Make the move optional and low-pressure. — "No need to respond; the call you made on timing was the right one."

**Close relationship**

Drop the technique feel and use ordinary language. — "You didn't have to do that, and it made my week easier."

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- Praise would embarrass the person in public
- The appreciation is really there to soften a hidden ask
- You don't actually mean it
- Being specific would expose confidential detail
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

**Day 1 — Spot the cues**

Across today, note five moments where someone did something specific worth appreciating: effort, good judgement, or a quiet save. Just notice; don't act on them yet.

**Day 2 — Name action and effect**

Take those five moments and write each as "I appreciated X because it helped Y." Cut anything vague, and make sure each names a real behaviour and a real effect.

**Day 3 — Say it like you**

Read each line aloud until it sounds like you rather than a script. Bin any that sound polished, corporate or performative.

**Day 4 — Use one live**

In a real conversation, deliver one specific appreciation. Keep it to a single sentence, then stop and let it sit.

**Day 5 — Calibrate**

Use it twice more today and watch the response. Note which cues told you it landed and which told you to shorten it or let it go.

**Day 6 — Practise repair**

Deliberately deliver one slightly-off appreciation, then use a recovery line such as "I may have read that wrong; what actually helped?" Get comfortable repairing without flinching.

### Day 7 — Match tone to context

Use the move in three different settings today (work, a text, a close relationship) and adjust the wording to fit each. Reflect on what you changed and why.

#### **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I name a specific behaviour, not just a vague quality?
- Did I keep it to roughly one sentence?
- Did I mean it, with no hidden ask attached?
- Did I read the room: hierarchy, culture, and whether they'd want this said publicly?
- Did I watch their response and adjust?
- Did I repair quickly if it missed?